

THE TWENTY-TWO LETTERS

#	Modern	Paleo	Name	Sound	Meaning	Gematria
1			Aleph	<i>silent / glottal stop</i>	<i>Ox</i>	1
2			Bet	<i>b / v</i>	<i>House</i>	2
3			Gimel	<i>g (hard)</i>	<i>Throwstick</i>	3
4			Dalet	<i>d</i>	<i>Door</i>	4
5			He	<i>h</i>	<i>Behold / Window</i>	5
6			Waw	<i>v / w</i>	<i>Hook / Nail</i>	6
7			Zayin	<i>z</i>	<i>Weapon</i>	7
8			Het	<i>ch (guttural)</i>	<i>Fence</i>	8
9			Tet	<i>t</i>	<i>Wheel / Basket</i>	9
10			Yod	<i>y</i>	<i>Hand / Arm</i>	10
11			Kaph	<i>k / kh</i>	<i>Palm</i>	20

THE TWENTY-TWO LETTERS, CONTINUED

#	Modern	Paleo	Name	Sound	Meaning	Gematria
12			Lamed	<i>l</i>	<i>Goad</i>	30
13			Mem	<i>m</i>	<i>Water</i>	40
14			Nun	<i>n</i>	<i>Snake / Fish</i>	50
15			Samekh	<i>s</i>	<i>Pillar / Support</i>	60
16			Ayin	<i>silent / guttural</i>	<i>Eye</i>	70
17			Pe	<i>p / f</i>	<i>Mouth</i>	80
18			Tsade	<i>ts</i>	<i>Plant / Hook</i>	90
19			Qoph	<i>q (k)</i>	<i>Needle's Eye</i>	100
20			Resh	<i>r</i>	<i>Head</i>	200
21			Shin	<i>sh / s</i>	<i>Bow / Tooth</i>	300
22			Taw	<i>t</i>	<i>Mark / Sign</i>	400

*"Gematria" assigns numeric weight to each Hebrew letter, a tradition long used in scriptural study.
The Paleo-Hebrew forms shown trace each letter to its ancient pictographic root.*

THE PALEO-HEBREW ALPHABET

Aleph – Taw • Ancient Pictographic Script

01



Aleph

02



Bet

03



Gimel

04



Dalet

05



He

06



Waw

07



Zayin

08



Het

09



Tet

10



Yod

11



Kaph

12



Lamed

13



Mem

14



Nun

15



Samekh

16



Ayin

17



Pe

18



Tsade

19



Qoph

20



Resh

21



Shin

22



Taw

THE MODERN HEBREW ALPHABET

Aleph – Taw • Ashurit Square Script

01



Aleph

02



Bet

03



Gimel

04



Dalet

05



He

06



Waw

07



Zayin

08



Het

09



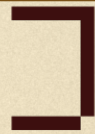
Tet

10



Yod

11



Kaph

12



Lamed

13



Mem

14



Nun

15



Samekh

16



Ayin

17



Pe

18



Tsade

19



Qoph

20



Resh

21



Shin

22



Taw

THE SACRED ALPHABET

Modern Hebrew • Ancient Paleo-Script • Gematria Values

A BRIEF HISTORY

The alphabet's earliest known form arose roughly 3,800 years ago among Semitic-speaking laborers in the Sinai peninsula and Egypt. Borrowing the visual shapes of Egyptian hieroglyphs but assigning each symbol the sound of its Semitic name — a device scholars call the acrophonic principle — these workers created what is now known as the Proto-Sinaitic script, the ancestor of nearly every alphabet used in the world today.

By roughly 1050 BCE, this script had matured into the Phoenician alphabet: a streamlined set of twenty-two consonantal letters carried by Phoenician merchants across the Mediterranean. It became the direct parent of Paleo-Hebrew and Aramaic, and, later, of Greek and Latin.

Paleo-Hebrew — the pictographic forms shown at right in this chart — was used by the ancient Israelites for over a thousand years, appearing on seals, coins, and portions of early manuscripts. During and after the Babylonian exile of the sixth century BCE, the Aramaic script gradually displaced it in everyday use. That Aramaic-derived form evolved into the square “Ashurit” script — the modern Hebrew alphabet used today.

Each letter also carries a gematria value: a numeric equivalent assigned since antiquity and used for symbolic and interpretive study of sacred texts.

